In a scene worthy of a spy novel, the three people had just confirmed each other's identities. The man with the Rubik's Cube was Edward Snowden, age 29. The people waiting for him were journalist Glenn Greenwald, age 46, and filmmaker Laura Poitras, age 49.

Secret Conversations

A few minutes later, the three arrived at Snowden's hotel room. Under Snowden's guidance, they stored their cell phones inside the room's minifridge after first removing the batteries. They shoved pillows around the cracks in the door to avoid being overheard. As a former employee for the top-secret Central Intelligence Agency (CIA), and then for contractors of the National Security Agency (NSA), Snowden knew firsthand how cunning government surveillance could be. The government would not be happy with what he was about to do, and he feared being discovered.

As Snowden explained to Poitras and Greenwald during the next several days, he wanted to go public with a trove of thousands of documents he had accessed and copied to flash drives while working for two NSA contracting companies, Dell and Booz Allen

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